

Toxic waters

PUNJAB and Haryana are facing an **escalating** groundwater crisis, with toxic **contamination**, **reckless extraction** and poor water management pushing the region towards disaster. The situation demands urgent **intervention** before **irreversible** damage threatens public health, agriculture and the environment. The latest Central Ground Water Board report **exposes alarming** levels of uranium, nitrates, arsenic and fluoride in groundwater in both states. In Punjab, uranium contamination has spread to 20 districts, while 16 in Haryana exceed safe limits. The excessive **use** of phosphate fertilisers, along with aggressive groundwater extraction, **has worsened** the crisis. **Prolonged exposure** to **uranium-laced** water **can** cause kidney **toxicity** and urinary tract cancers, yet the response remains **sluggish**.

Punjab's **worsening** water crisis is **exacerbated** by its **unsustainable** agricultural practices. A 2019 study warned that groundwater at 100 m would be **exhausted** within a **decade**. Five years later, farmers are still forced to **rely on** borewells due to the government's failure to promote crop **diversification**. **Paddy farming**, which **guzzles** thousands of litres per kilogram, **continues** to **drain** reserves, pushing the state toward **desertification**. **Adding to** the crisis is Punjab's mismanagement of wastewater. Instead of investing in sewage treatment plants, authorities have **resorted to deepening** village ponds to **contain** sewage overflow. This reckless practice **contaminates** sub-soil water, **posing** a severe health **hazard**. The Punjab and Haryana High Court has rightfully questioned the legality and environmental impact of such measures.



Amid this **bleak scenario**, Haryana's **commitment** to the Aravalli Green Wall Project **offers** a ray of **hope**. If implemented effectively, **afforestation**, groundwater recharge and soil conservation efforts could help **combat** desertification. However, promises must translate into **concrete** action. The region's water crisis can no longer be ignored. Governments must **enforce** stricter regulations, **curb** over-extraction and invest in **sustainable** solutions before North India's most **vital** resource **runs out**.

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

[\[Practice Exercise\]](#)

Vocabulary

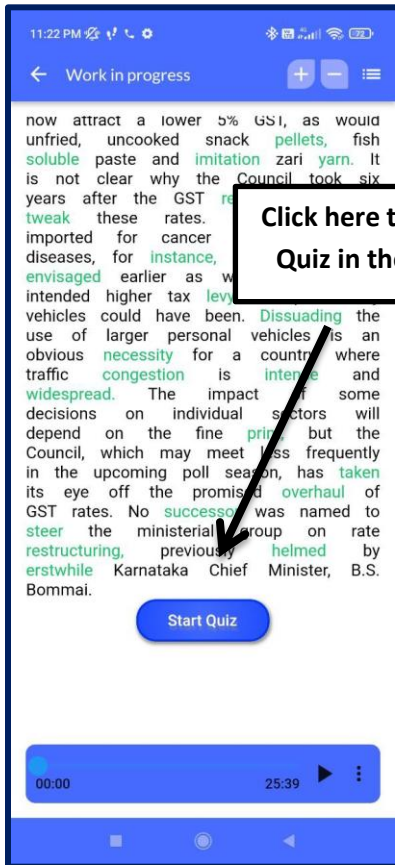
1. **Toxic** (adjective) – Poisonous, Harmful, Deadly, Noxious, Dangerous विषैला
2. **Escalating** (adjective) – Increasing, Rising, Growing, Intensifying, Mounting बढ़ता हुआ
3. **Contamination** (noun) – Pollution, Impurity, Infection, Toxicity, Defilement दूषण
4. **Reckless** (adjective) – Careless, Irresponsible, Rash, Negligent, Heedless लापरवाह
5. **Extraction** (noun) – Removal, Withdrawal, Mining, Drawing, Pumping निष्कर्षण
6. **Intervention** (noun) – Involvement, Mediation, Interference, Action, Step हस्तक्षेप
7. **Irreversible** (adjective) – Permanent, Unchangeable, Irrevocable, Final, Irreparable अपरिवर्तनीय
8. **Expose** (verb) – Reveal, Uncover, Disclose, Unveil, Show उजागर करना
9. **Alarming** (adjective) – Disturbing, Worrying, Frightening, Shocking, Startling चिंताजनक
10. **Worsen** (verb) – Deteriorate, Aggravate, Decline, Degrade, Intensify बिगड़ना
11. **Prolonged** (adjective) – Extended, Lengthy, Protracted, Long-lasting, Drawn-out लंबे समय तक
12. **Exposure** (noun) – Contact, Encounter, Experience, Subjection, Vulnerability संपर्क
13. **Uranium-laced** (adjective) – Contaminated, Polluted, Tainted, Infused, Mixed यूरेनियम मिश्रित
14. **Toxicity** (noun) – Poisonousness, Harmfulness, Venom, Noxiousness, Deadliness विषाक्तता
15. **Sluggish** (adjective) – Slow, Lethargic, Inactive, Sluggard, Dull सुस्त
16. **Worsening** (adjective) – Deteriorating, Declining, Aggravating, Degrading, Intensifying बिगड़ता हुआ
17. **Exacerbate** (verb) – Aggravate, Worsen, Intensify, Inflammate, Escalate बढ़ाना
18. **Unsustainable** (adjective) – Unviable, Unmaintainable, Unworkable, Exhaustible, Unendurable अस्थिर
19. **Exhaust** (verb) – Deplete, Drain, Consume, Empty, Use up खत्म करना
20. **Decade** (noun) – Period of ten years दशक
21. **Rely** (on) (verb) – Depend, Count, Trust, Bank, Lean निर्भर होना

22. **Diversification** (noun) – Variety, Variation, Expansion, Differentiation, Spread
विविधीकरण
23. **Guzzle** (verb) – Consume, Devour, Swallow, Drain, Drink बहुत (पानी) पीना
24. **Drain** (verb) – Deplete, Empty, Exhaust, Sap, Bleed खाली करना
25. **Desertification** (noun) – Aridification, Drought, Dryness, Land degradation, Barrenness मरुस्थलीकरण
26. **Add** (to) (verb) – Increase, Augment, Enhance, Amplify, Escalate बढ़ाना
27. **Resort** (to) (verb) – Turn to, Use, Employ, Utilize, Adopt सहारा लेना
28. **Deepen** (verb) – Intensify, Increase, Strengthen, Enhance, Widen गहरा करना
29. **Contain** (verb) – Hold, Include, Enclose, Restrain, Control रोकना
30. **Contaminate** (verb) – Pollute, Taint, Infect, Defile, Poison दूषित करना
31. **Pose** (verb) – Present, Create, Cause, Raise, Introduce खड़ा करना
32. **Hazard** (noun) – Danger, Risk, Threat, Peril, Jeopardy खतरा
33. **Bleak** (adjective) – Grim, Gloomy, Dismal, Hopeless, Depressing निराशाजनक
34. **Scenario** (noun) – Situation, Context, Setting, Circumstance, Background परिदृश्य
35. **Commitment** (noun) – Dedication, Devotion, Pledge, Promise, Obligation प्रतिबद्धता
36. **A ray of hope** (phrase) – Definition: A small sign of hope in a difficult situation. उम्मीद की किरण
37. **Afforestation** (noun) – Reforestation, Planting, Greening, Tree-planting, Forestation वनीकरण
38. **Combat** (verb) – Fight, Battle, Confront, Oppose, Resist लड़ना
39. **Concrete** (adjective) – Specific, Tangible, Definite, Solid, Real ठोस
40. **Enforce** (verb) – Implement, Apply, Impose, Execute, Administer लागू करना
41. **Curb** (verb) – Restrict, Control, Limit, Suppress, Check रोकना
42. **Sustainable** (adjective) – Eco-friendly, Renewable, Viable, Enduring, Maintainable टिकाऊ
43. **Vital** (adjective) – Essential, Crucial, Important, Critical, Indispensable महत्वपूर्ण
44. **Run out** (phrasal verb) – Definition: To exhaust or deplete a resource completely. खत्म होना

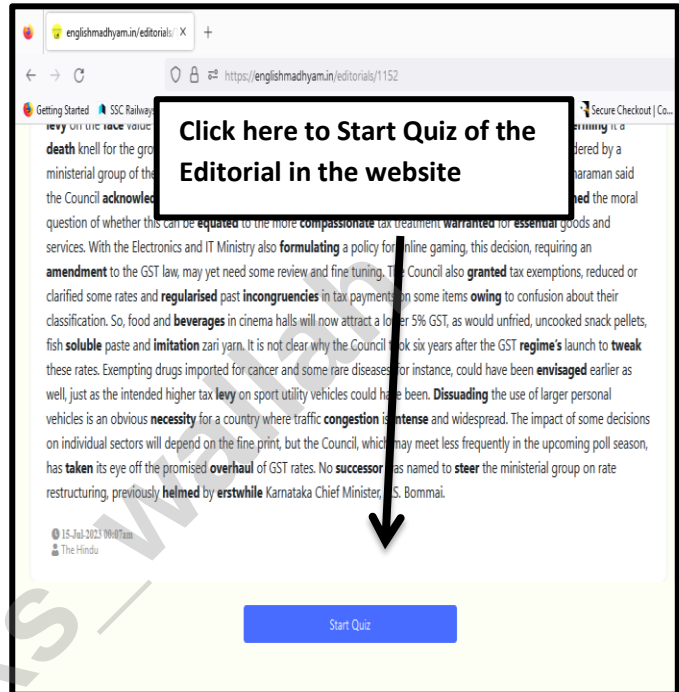
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Groundwater Contamination:** Punjab and Haryana face severe groundwater contamination, with unsafe levels of uranium, nitrates, arsenic, and fluoride.
2. **Health Risks:** Prolonged exposure to uranium-contaminated water can cause kidney toxicity and urinary tract cancers, posing a significant public health threat.
3. **Uranium Spread:** In Punjab, uranium contamination has affected 20 districts, while 16 districts in Haryana exceed safe limits.
4. **Agricultural Practices:** Unsustainable farming, particularly paddy cultivation, exacerbates groundwater depletion in Punjab, with reserves at 100 m depth predicted to be exhausted within a decade.
5. **Crop Diversification Failure:** Despite warnings, the government has failed to promote crop diversification, forcing farmers to rely on borewells.
6. **Wastewater Mismanagement:** Punjab's inadequate sewage treatment and reliance on deepening village ponds to contain sewage overflow further contaminate groundwater.
7. **High Court Intervention:** The Punjab and Haryana High Court has questioned the legality and environmental impact of current wastewater management practices.
8. **Desertification Threat:** Unsustainable water use and mismanagement are pushing Punjab toward desertification.
9. **Haryana's Green Initiative:** Haryana's Aravalli Green Wall Project offers hope through afforestation, groundwater recharge, and soil conservation efforts.
10. **Need for Action:** Promises of sustainable solutions must be translated into concrete measures to address the crisis.
11. **Stricter Regulations:** Governments must enforce stricter regulations to curb over-extraction and contamination of groundwater.
12. **Sustainable Solutions:** Investment in sustainable water management practices, such as sewage treatment plants and crop diversification, is urgently needed.
13. **Public Awareness:** Raising awareness about the health risks of contaminated water and the importance of conservation is crucial.
14. **Inter-State Cooperation:** Punjab and Haryana must collaborate to address the shared water crisis effectively.
15. **Urgency:** Immediate intervention is required to prevent irreversible damage to public health, agriculture, and the environment in the region.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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